

Pre-Class Assignment: Balwit Essay

“Career Advice from the AI Frontier”

ECON 470 — Microeconomics of Artificial Intelligence

Spring 2026

Reading: Avital Balwit, “‘Career’ Advice from the AI Frontier: Preparing Young People for Work in the Age of Transformative AI,” *The Digitalist Papers*, Vol. 2 (2024). Available at digitalistpapers.com/vol2/balwit.

Due: In person, Wednesday April 22, at the start of class.

Instructions: Answer each question in 1–3 sentences. These are reading-check questions — they should be quick if you read the essay. You must submit this assignment in person. The assignment must be handwritten. No photocopies will be accepted.

Why we do this: A team of your classmates is presenting this essay and leading a 10-minute discussion afterward. These questions ensure you arrive ready to participate.

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1. Balwit argues that AI differs from previous labor-displacing technologies (steam engines, assembly lines) in a fundamental way. What is it?
 2. What does Balwit mean by the shift from being an “individual contributor” to being a “manager” of AI systems? Give one concrete example she uses.
 3. Balwit identifies four “uniquely human advantages” that she believes will remain valuable. Name two of them.
 4. Balwit discusses the risk of tying one’s identity to intelligence. What does she propose instead, and why?
 5. Pick one of Balwit’s policy proposals (on education or employment) that you found either compelling or unconvincing. State the proposal in one sentence, then say why you reacted the way you did.